The Face of Crime in Prime Time: Evidence from Law and Order*

Gaurav Sood† Daniel Trielli‡

Abstract

We tally the coded race and gender of victims and criminals in 731 episodes of three Law & Order series. The share of classified criminal characters coded Black is 7.7% in *Criminal Intent*, 9.9% in *Special Victims Unit*, and 11.2% in the sampled seasons of the original series. These shares are below the historical arrest benchmarks. The corresponding Black victim shares are 9.3%, 10.8%, and 10.4%, below the share in the historical serious-violent-victimization benchmark. Women are more common among coded criminal characters than among people arrested for the compared offenses. The comparisons describe these episodes and the available historical reference series; they do not measure what viewers learned from watching them.

*Data and scripts behind the analysis presented here can be downloaded at: https://github.com/notnews/face_of_crime.

†Gaurav can be reached at gsood07@gmail.com

‡Daniel is a professional journalist. He can be reached at: dtrielli@gmail.com

Offensive portrayals of African Americans on entertainment shows have long been the norm in the US. For instance, minstrel shows, popular in the 19th century and the first half of the 20th century, regularly portrayed African Americans as lazy and dim-witted (Dates and Barlow 1993; Toll 1974). More recently, Entman and Rojecki (2001) found that 56% of blacks in the media were portrayed as violent compared to 11% of the whites.

There is good reason to think that these offensive portrayals reinforce negative stereotypes of African Americans. For at least some people likely take these portrayals as representative of African Americans (see Punyanunt-Carter 2008). Correspondingly, research suggests that belief in aversive racial stereotypes is associated with exposure to television programming (Busselle and Crandall 2002; Entman and Rojecki 2001; Armstrong and Neuendorf 1992). For instance, exposure to television news is correlated with the extent to which college students endorse that blacks are lazy (Busselle and Crandall 2002). Similarly, Armstrong and Neuendorf (1992) find that more television news the college students consumed, more likely they were to believe that blacks have lower socio-economic outcomes. (Albeit, "TV drama exposure was associated with beliefs that Black Americans had a relatively higher socio-economic standing.") A more comprehensive study of how blacks are portrayed in the media by Entman and Rojecki (2001) reached similar conclusions—exposure to nonfictional portrayals of African Americans is associated with negative stereotypes of blacks.

Television's role in perpetuating negative stereotypes is worrisome because of how consequential stereotypes are in shaping attitudes, preferences, and behavior. Much research shows that racial stereotypes shape political attitudes (see, for e.g., Sniderman and Piazza

1995; Hurwitz and Peffley 1997; Peffley et al. 1997; Dixon 2006) and affect economic behavior (see, for e.g., Bertrand and Mullainathan 2004).

Given the concern, numerous researchers study how blacks are covered on various television programs (for e.g., Entman and Rojecki 2001; Eschholz et al. 2004). One particular focus of the effort—given blacks are stereotyped as violent and criminal, and given the impact such stereotypes may have on policy consequential attitudes related to punitiveness—has been on describing the extent to which blacks are overrepresented as criminals, especially as violent criminals.

Studies on the extent to which blacks are overrepresented in crime news or other programming about crime suggest that the bias is generally small but very variable—some studies document a modest anti-black bias in some news programs in some areas of the country (Gilliam et al. 1996), while others document a large anti-white bias (when compared to criminal arrest data, which are likely biased in favor of whites) (Chiricos and Eschholz 2002; Dixon and Linz 2000; Eschholz et al. 2004) (see Table 1).

In this paper, we add to this body of work. We tally the gender and race of criminals and victims depicted in three Law & Order series and compare their composition with historical arrest records, victim surveys, and population data. The series, offense categories, places, and years differ across those sources, so the comparisons describe the coded portrayals in context.

Table 1: Racial distribution of perpetrators and victims in earlier television studies

Region	Period	Media	Finding	Citation
Hampton Roads, Virginia	Jan. 3-31, 2011	Local TV News	Perpetrators: 50.7% Blacks (Violent Crime), 75% Whites (White Collar Crime), 75.9% Blacks (General Crime) (Graph 4) Victims: 78.3% White (Violent Crime), 82.1% Whites (General Crime) (Graph 5)	Agarwal et al. (2011)
National	1994–1997, 2000	Network News	Perpetrators: All Crime: 71% White (vs. 68% in Uniform Crime Reports), 27% Blacks (vs. 30% in Uniform Crime Reports) (Table 4) Violent Crime: 48% White (vs. 56% in Uniform Crime Reports), 38% Blacks (vs. 42% in Uniform Crime Reports) (Table 5) Victims: All Crime: 51% White (vs. 28% in Uniform Crime Reports), 30% Blacks (vs. 48% in Uniform Crime Reports) (Table 6)	Dixon et al. (2003)
National	2002–2003	Local TV News	Perpetrator (All Crime): 26.82% White, 21.06% Black, 42.27% Not Indicated Victim (All Crime): 27.88% White, 9.24% Black, 56.97% Not Indicated (Table 1)	Bjornstrom et al. (2010)
National	2000–2001	NYPD Blue and Law and Order	NYPD Blue: Offender: 50% Whites (vs. 68% in Uniform Crime Reports), 38% Blacks, 11% Violent Off./Sus. 43% (black) 46% (white) 10% Law and Order Figures don't add up to 100. (Table 1)	Eschholz et al. (2004)
Washington, D.C.	May and June 2005	Local TV News	Perpetrators: Violent Crime: 9% Whites, 32% Blacks, 51% Unrevealed Non-violent Crime: 14% Whites, 29% Blacks, 50% Unrevealed Victims: Violent Crime: 15% White, 10% Blacks, 72% Unrevealed Non-violent Crime: 3% White, 7% Blacks, 83% Unrevealed	Gross (2006)
Los Angeles	1995–1996	Local TV News	All Perpetrators: 37% Black (versus 21% in California Department of Justice Criminal Profile or CDJCP), 21% (versus 28% in CDJCP) (Table 4) Felons: 44% Black (versus 25% in CDJCP), 18% (versus 23% in CDJCP) (Table 5)	Dixon and Linz (2000)
Los Angeles	1993–1994	Local TV News (KABC)	No commensurate numbers, except: 40% where race identified (purportedly across all crime stories). Where race identified in violent crime stories: 45% White and in non-violent crime: 75% white. Blacks actual crime rate: 2.8 * share of population. Coverage: 3.2 * share of population. (Assuming the coverage is estimated as percentage where race identified and not as percentage of total mentions) (Figure 2) Non-violent crime: Whites overrepresented by nearly 400% (see Figure 3)	Gilliam et al. (1996)
Orlando	1998	Local TV News	All Crime: 18% Black (Versus 42% Arrest Rate), 65% White (Versus 58% Arrest Rate) (Table 3) Violent Crime: 20% Black (Versus 49% Arrest Rate), 61% White (Versus 51% Arrest Rate)(Table 3)	Chiricos and Eschholz (2002)

Learning from Television

Mass media is an important part of the information environment for many people. Thus, what is covered in the media tends to affect what people believe (Gerbner et al. 1986; Shanahan and Morgan 1999). For instance, exposure to more vivid violent media causes people to think that crime and police immorality are more common in the real world (Riddle 2010). Similarly, the extent to which a topic is covered on television news affects how important people think it is (McCombs and Shaw 1972; Iyengar and Kinder 2010; Iyengar 1990).

Similar mechanism likely holds when someone watches one of the tens of hundreds of crime dramas on television. A person watching a crime drama, aware of its fictional nature, may still inadvertently think that the drama accurately 'mirrors' society. For instance, people perceive negative personality traits of African Americans portrayed on television as true to life (Punyanunt-Carter 2008). These inference are liable to be encouraged by prior interpretation and acceptance of flawed—because they are imprecise—statements such as 'art reflects life' as true.

Increasingly common mass-media tropes such as realism in depiction and explicit statements designed to cue realism may also increase the chances that people take fictional portrayals as reasonably accurate depictions of reality. As a case in point, all Law & Order *Special Victims Unit* series episodes start with the statement: "...In New York City, the dedicated detectives who investigate these vicious felonies are members of an elite squad known as the Special Victims Unit. These are their stories." It is not unreasonable to think

that some people listening to the statement may come to think that the crimes covered in the drama represent a broad, perhaps representative, set of all "sexually based crimes."

Besides learning about the extent of crime and what kind of crime is prevalent from television, people may also learn associations between kinds of people and criminal activity, especially when people involved are (superficially) distinctive—say, in the color of their skin. The logic goes that if certain kinds of people are frequently shown as perpetrators of crime, people may come to believe that as large a share of perpetrators belongs to that group. By the same token, over-representation of certain groups as victims may promote misleading views of what populations are the most vulnerable to crime.

Data and Measurement

The data are from three Law & Order series: Original Law & Order series (Original), Law & Order: Special Victims Unit (SVU), and Law & Order: Criminal Intent (Criminal Intent). All the three shows are police procedurals set in New York City. Criminal Intent, which ran between 2001–2011, purportedly follows detectives of the 'Major Case Squad,' a division of the New York Police Department (NYPD) focused on solving major crimes against rich, famous, or important people. Meanwhile SVU, which has been on television since 1999, purportedly follows detectives of the NYPD division devoted to handling "sexually based offenses," the 'Special Victims Unit.'

The three series were long-running television programs. The episode coding in this study covers the original series in 1990–1991 and 2005–2010, Criminal Intent in 2001–2011,

and SVU in 1999–2016. The original audience-data script depends on files absent from this repository, so we do not report audience averages here.

For the Original series, we only have data from Seasons 1 and 2 (1990–1991) and Seasons 16–20 (2005–2010).[1] In all, we have data from 151 shows. For CI, we have 194 coded rows across its 10 seasons, spanning 2001–2011. And for SVU, we have 386 coded rows spanning seasons 1–17 and broadcast years 1999–2016. In all, across the three series, we have data from 731 shows, with 1,578 recorded victims and 1,117 recorded criminals; the race or gender of some characters was not classified. We coded the race and gender of all criminals and victims whose race and gender was identified.

We define criminals as characters whose guilt is very clearly indicated; our definition includes characters not convicted or even indicted for a crime. In line with the law, active instigators and financiers of crime were coded as criminals. We marked attempted crimes as such. Lastly, we focus on 'major' crimes, excluding infractions such as failing to comply with court orders.

We coded victims' and criminals' race as white, black, Asian, or Hispanic, following the general census guidelines.[2] Characters of Middle-Eastern descent were coded as white, but a note marking their specific background was included in the data. And under 'Hispanics,' we included non-Hispanic Latinos such as Brazilians.

In addition to the data on the race and gender of the victims and the criminals from the shows, we collected data on a few baselines. From the 1990, 2000, and 2010 census,

[1] The choice of the seasons is a reflection of what was available on streaming on Amazon Instant as of July, 2016.

[2] http://www.census.gov/topics/population/race/about.html

we collected data on the percentage of whites, blacks, and men in the US and in New York City. Like Dixon and Linz (2000), from the Federal Bureau of Investigation's Uniform Crime Report (UCR), we gathered data on the percentage of blacks, whites and men arrested for *All Crimes*, *Violent Crimes*, and *Sexually Based Crimes*. From New York Police Department's Crime and Enforcement Activity in New York City Report (NYPD),[3] we gathered data on the percentage of blacks, whites and Hispanics who were suspected of (and were victims of) murder, rape, assault and robbery each year between 2008 and 2015. Lastly, from the Bureau of Justice Statistics' National Crime Victimization Survey (NCVS) (Powers 2016; Victimization 1998), we gathered data on the race and gender of victims of crime.

The UCR data on race of alleged criminals is available for 1995–2015. In UCR, race is split into white, black, American Indian or Alaskan Native, Asian, and Native Hawaiian or Other Pacific Islander. The totals in these categories include Hispanics. Data on Hispanic background only began to be collected in 2013, and even then the race totals are not split by Hispanic ethnicity. Not separating out Hispanics naturally inflates the numbers for whites and blacks. But the inflation for blacks is quite modest. Nearly 93% of Hispanics self-identify as whites (Steffensmeier et al. 2011). And accounting for Hispanics changes the percentage of blacks rape and assault by generally no more than a couple of percentage points (see figure 4, Steffensmeier et al. 2011).[4] Thus, for the main analyses, which focus on representation of blacks and Hispanics, we utilize unadjusted numbers for blacks from UCR.

In UCR, 28 types of crimes are split into two categories: *Violent Crime* and *Property*

[3] http://www.nyc.gov/html/nypd/html/analysis_and_planning/crime_and_enforcement_activity.shtml

[4] Steffensmeier et al. (2011) adjust UCR data by leveraging arrest data from California and New York, where arrest data includes Hispanics.

Crime. *Violent Crime* includes murder and non-negligent manslaughter, rape, robbery, and aggravated assault. And *Property Crime* includes burglary, larceny-theft, motor vehicle theft, and arson. We collected data on the percentage of people arrested by race (white and black) and gender (male) for all crimes, violent crimes, as well as arrested for three of the most common offenses shown in the Law & Order shows: homicides, rapes, and assaults. (661 of 731 shows or just over 90% of the shows included in our data featured a rape, murder, or assault.)

Victim data from the NCVS covers the period between 1993–2014. Racial data in the NCVS can be gathered with Hispanics included in the category totals, and without. We collected both kinds of data, but focus on data that more closely matches our data for Law & Order, and separates out Hispanics.

Like the UCR, the NCVS aggregates various crimes into categories. In NCVS, however, the categories are *Violent Victimization* and *Serious Violent Victimization*. Both account for victims of rape, sexual assault, and robbery. *Violent Victimization*, however, tallies all types of assault, while *Serious Violent Victimization* only tallies aggravated assaults. Therefore, *Serious Violent Victimization* is the closest to the *Violent Crime* category in the UCR. Hence, we use data from that category. In addition, we also collect data for two specific offenses: rape/sexual assault and aggravated assault. Given that the NCVS data comes from interviews with victims, there is naturally no data on murders. Data on the race and gender of murder victims comes from UCR.[5]

[5]Since homicides almost always lead to the discovery of the bodies of victims, data on their gender and race are usually present. In 2015, for instance, there were 13,455 homicide victims. Of those, 29 (0.2 percent) were of an unknown gender. Thus, for data about gender of homicide victims, the percentages we use are

Results

To put the racial and gender breakdown of coded Law & Order characters in context, we compare the percentage of black and female criminals and victims on the three Law & Order shows to a variety of baselines. In the main text, we describe the percentage of black and female criminals and victims by show, same percentages for episodes featuring murder, and SVU episodes featuring rape. (Criminal Intent and Original had fewer than 10 episodes each where rape was one of the crimes.) We compare these to average percentage of black, Hispanic, and female criminals for all crimes, rape, and murder from the UCR, and percentage of black and female victims for murder, rape, and serious violent crimes over the available historical years. A series of graphs and tables in SI 1 and SI 2 break data down by year, and provide other baselines like data from the census that we don't include in the main text.

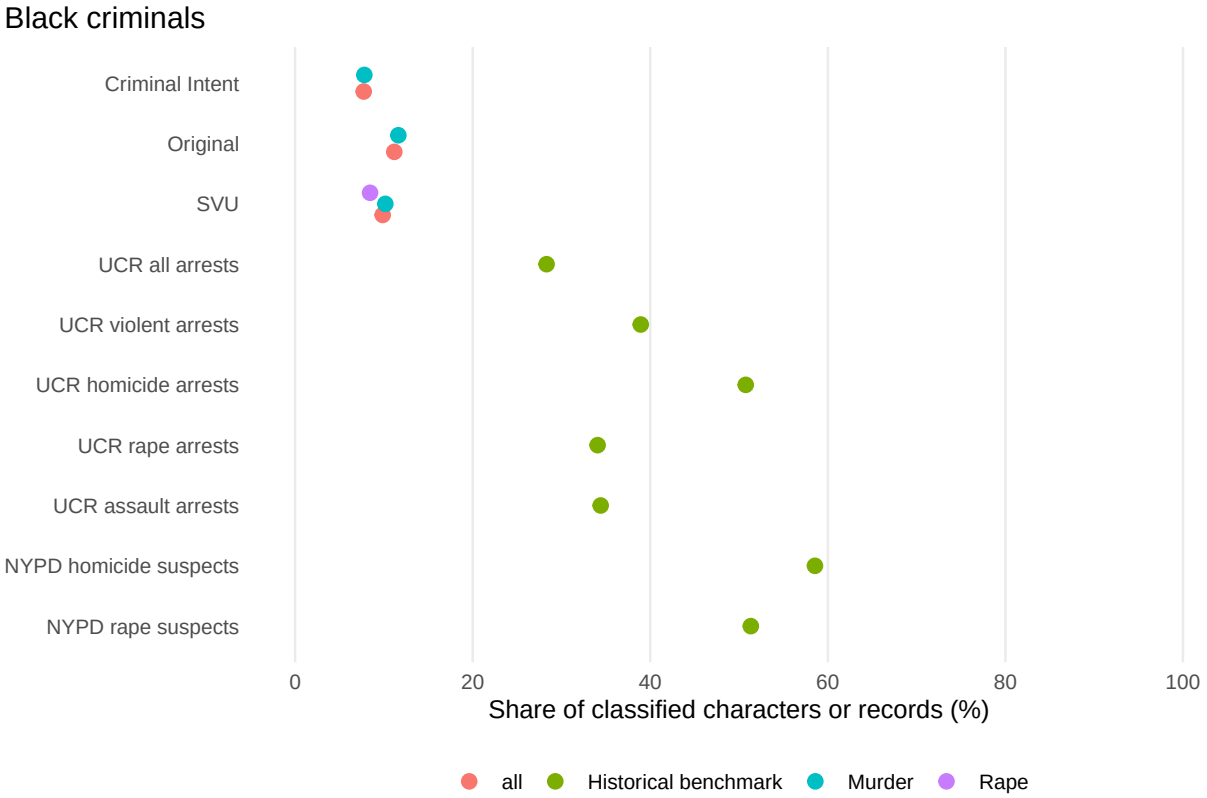
As Figures 1 and 2 show, the classified criminal characters are predominantly white: 86.4% in Criminal Intent, 81.7% in SVU, and 84.0% in Original. The Black shares are 7.7%, 9.9%, and 11.2%, respectively. These descriptive shares are lower than the corresponding historical arrest shares in the reference series. Arrests measure enforcement, not all crimes committed, and the crime mix differs between shows and benchmarks.

The annual Black criminal shares fluctuate across broadcast years (Figure SI 1.1 and

the same offered by the UCR, which are calculated on the total of homicide victims, even the ones whose gender is unknown as that has a negligible impact on the final numbers. For instance, if we include victims with unknown gender—which is done by UCR—78.8 percent of all victims were male. Excluding those, the percentage changes to 79.0 percent. For perpetrators, we also use percentages offered by the UCR, but there is a high number of perpetrators unknown gender. Therefore, the percentages are based on the total of perpetrators whose gender is known.

Table SI 2.2). The table also shows changes in the historical rape-arrest series around the FBI's 2012 definition change. Those values cannot by themselves isolate the effect of the definition change or provide a matched comparison with the shows.

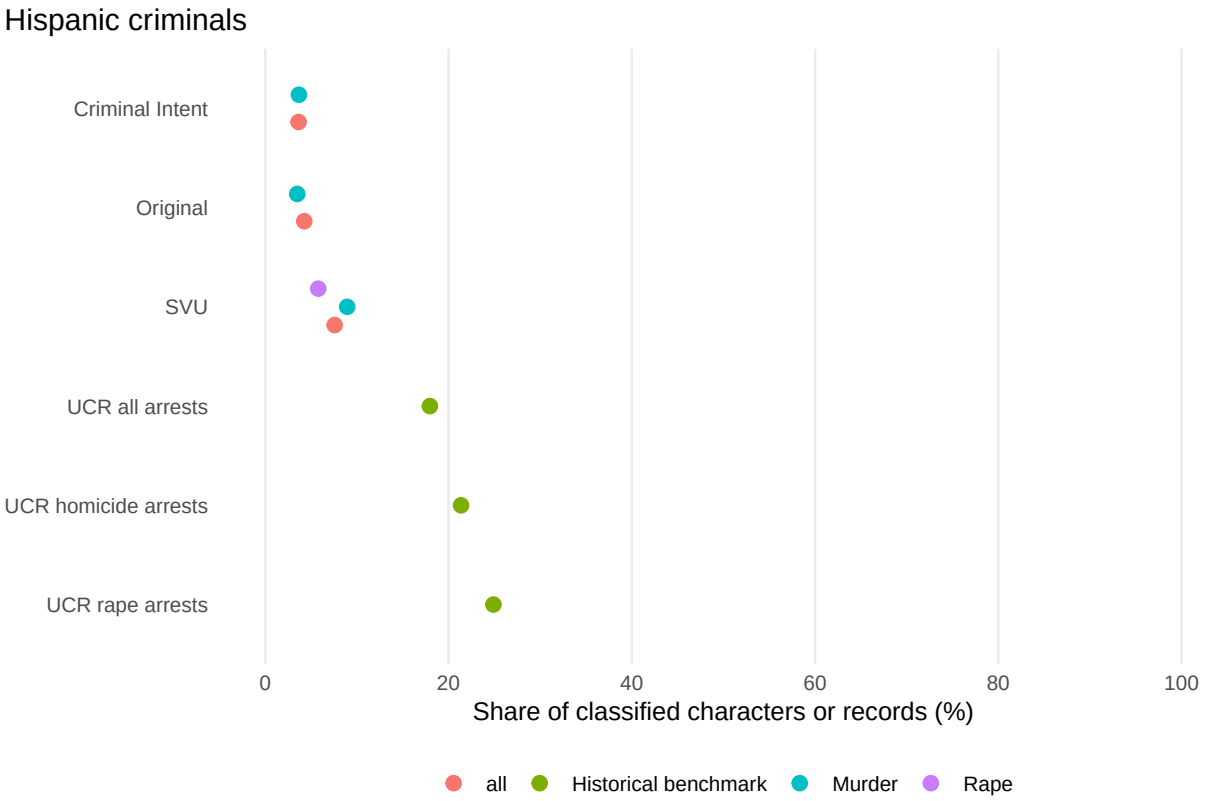
Figure 1: Share of Black Criminals in Law & Order and Historical Reference Series



Show values count classified characters. Benchmarks average available years in the original source files; periods differ.

White characters also account for most classified victims (Figure 3). The Black victim shares are 9.3% in Criminal Intent, 10.8% in SVU, and 10.4% in Original. For comparison, the historical NCVS Black share averaged 19.8% for serious violent victimization, 15.2% for rape or sexual assault, and 19.4% for aggravated assault during 1999–2014. The UCR Black share of murder victims averaged 48.7% over the available years. These categories differ in

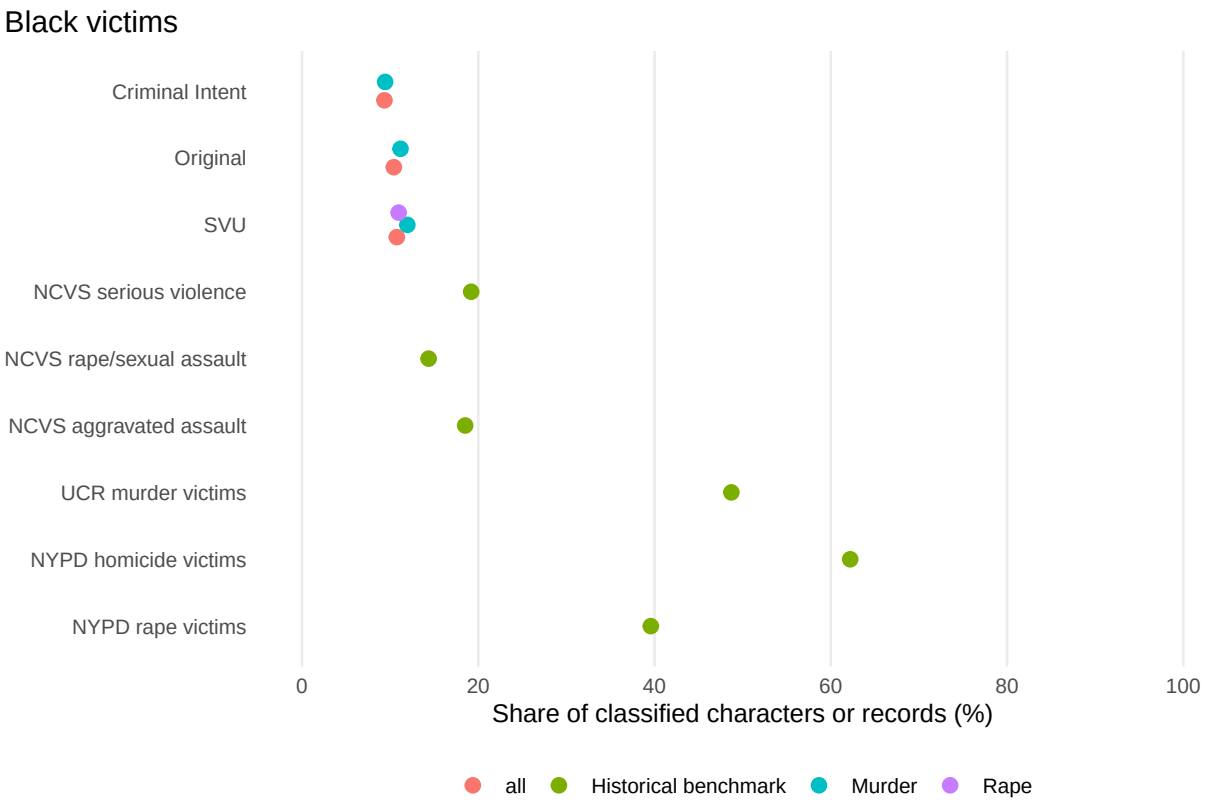
Figure 2: Share of Hispanic Criminals in Law & Order and Historical Reference Series



Show values count classified characters. Benchmarks average available years in the original source files; periods differ.

offense mix, geography, years, and reporting process; the comparisons are descriptive rather than like-for-like estimates. Annual show values appear in Figure SI 1.2 and Table SI 2.1.

Figure 3: Share of Black Victims in Law & Order and Historical Reference Series

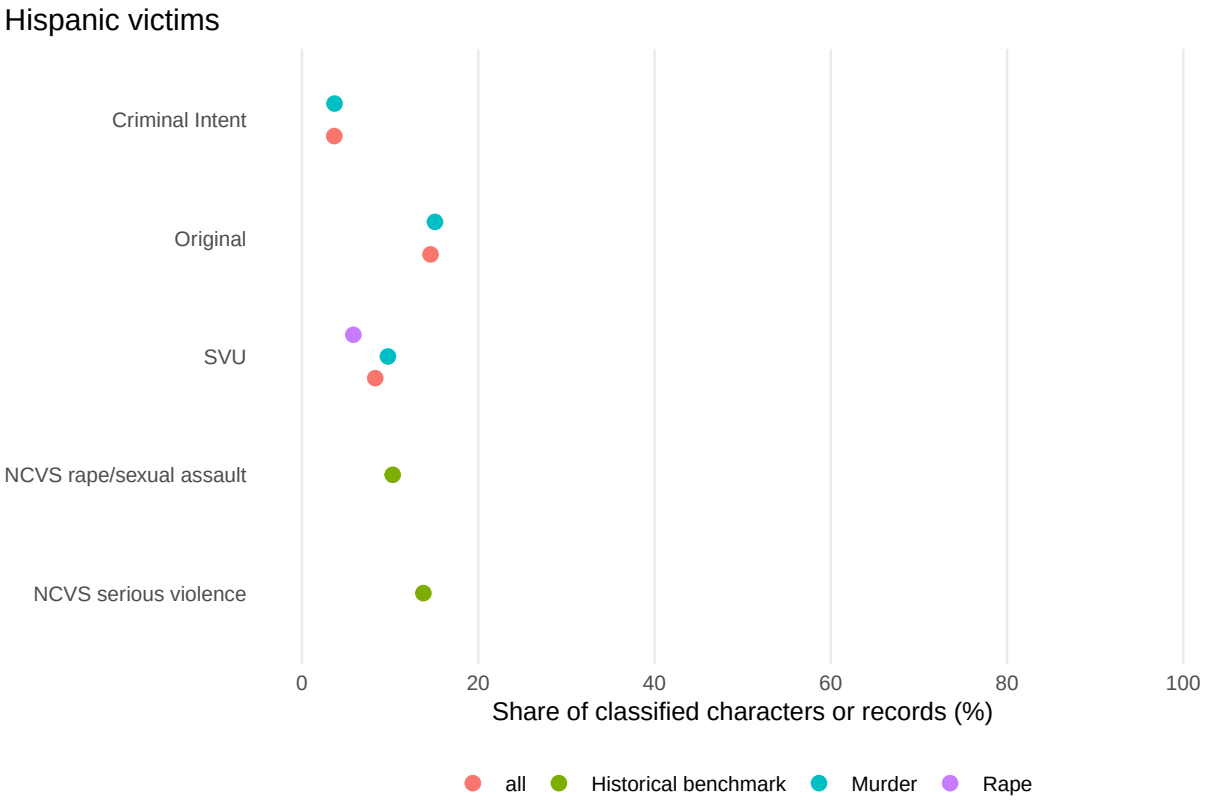


Show values count classified characters. Benchmarks average available years in the original source files; periods differ.

Women account for 31.9% of classified criminals in Criminal Intent, 27.4% in SVU, and 26.8% in Original (Figure 5). These proportions exceed the female shares in the historical UCR arrest categories shown in the figure. Annual show shares and year-specific UCR comparisons appear in Figure SI 1.3 and Table SI 2.4.

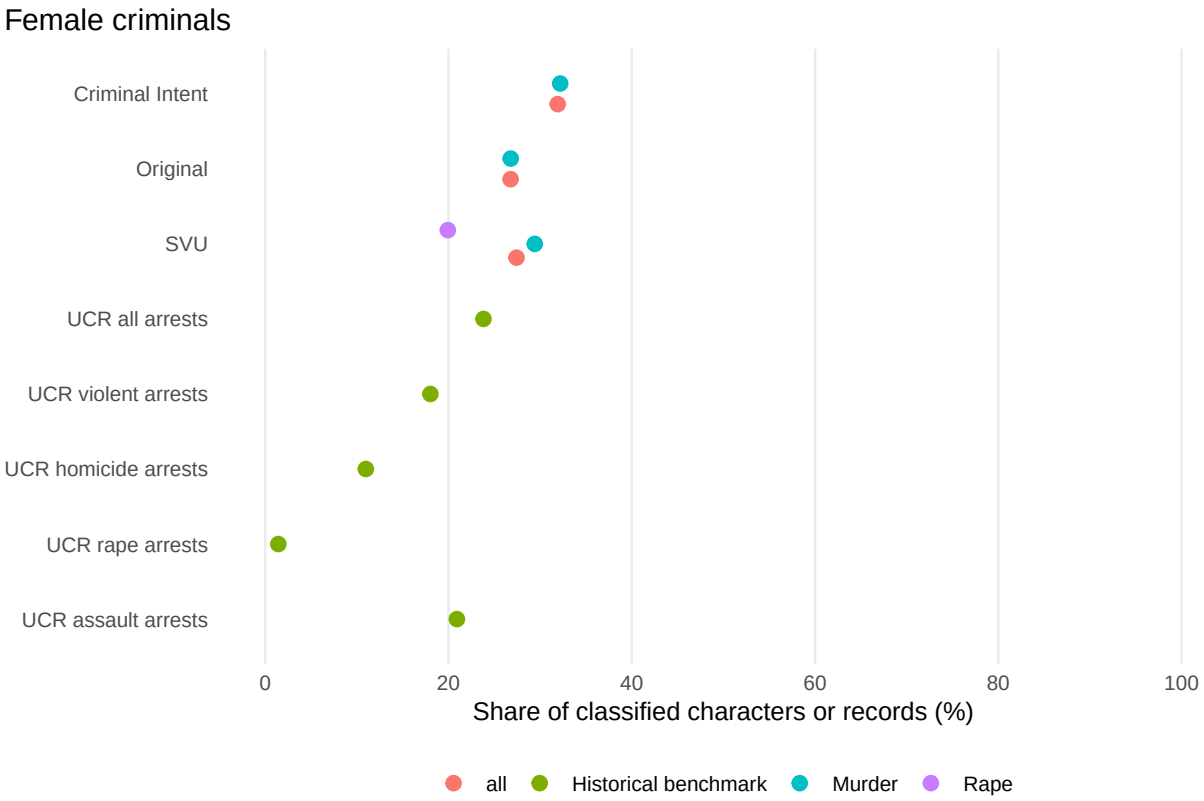
Women account for 42.7% of classified victims in Criminal Intent, 60.9% in SVU, and 40.3% in Original (Figure 6). In the historical NCVS files, women account for 46.1%

Figure 4: Share of Hispanic Victims in Law & Order and Historical Reference Series



Show values count classified characters. Benchmarks average available years in the original source files; periods differ.

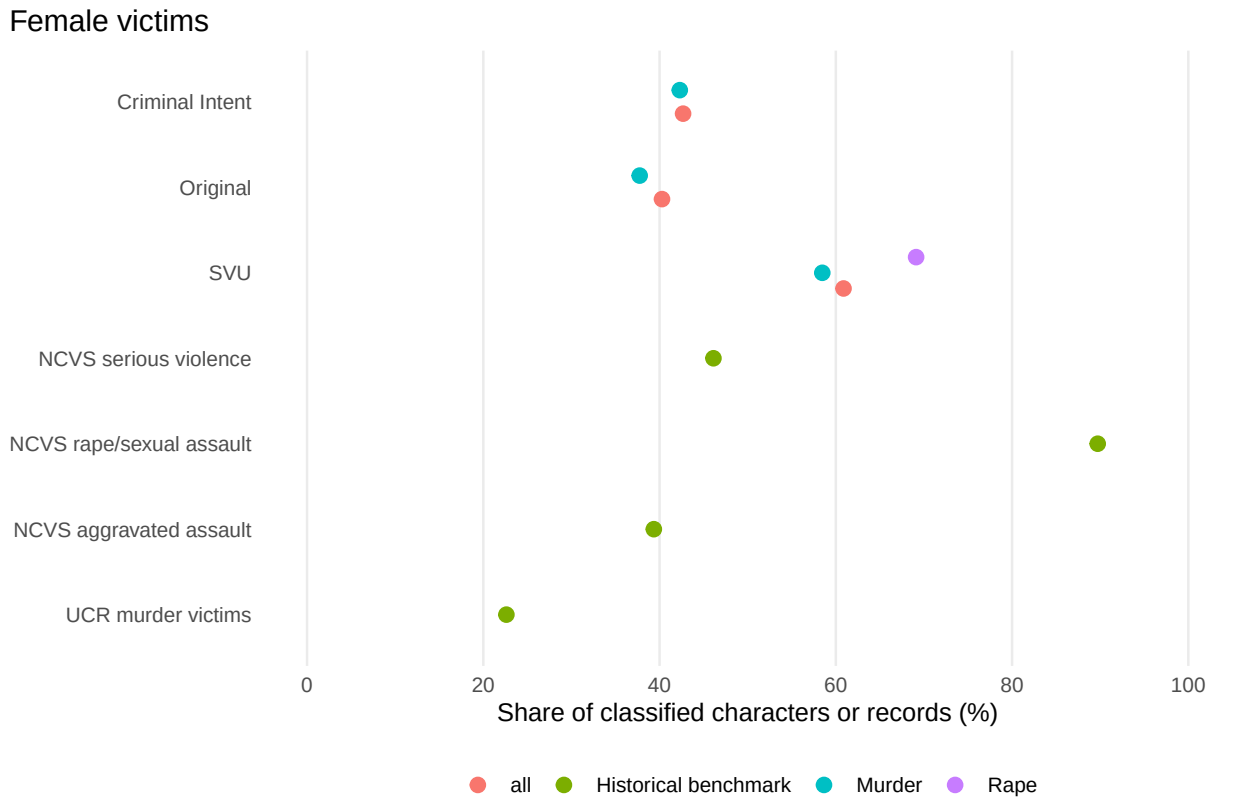
Figure 5: Share of Female Criminals in Law & Order and Historical Reference Series



Show values count classified characters. Benchmarks average available years in the original source files; periods differ.

of serious violent victimizations and 89.7% of rape or sexual-assault victimizations. Their share of UCR murder victims averages 22.6%. The show and reference categories do not have the same offense mix. Annual values are shown in Figure SI 1.4 and Table SI 2.3.

Figure 6: Share of Female Victims in Law & Order and Historical Reference Series



Show values count classified characters. Benchmarks average available years in the original source files; periods differ.

Discussion

Popular television is our bay window to the world. What we see on television likely has a sizable influence on how we think about the world. In particular, television programming likely influences how we think about crime, how common we think it is, especially in our

communities, who we think perpetrates it, the reasons why criminals do what they do, who the victims are, the efficacy of the police and judicial systems, among other things.

Across these coded episodes, Black characters account for smaller shares of classified criminals and victims than the Black shares in several historical arrest and victimization series. Female criminal characters account for larger shares than women in several arrest categories. The size of each difference depends on the crime category, years, geography, and the exclusion of unclassified characters. The episode census supports claims about portrayal in these three series and sampled seasons. Whether these portrayals change viewers' beliefs remains a separate question.

Several mechanisms might produce these patterns. The series select different offenses and stories, and the characters visible in each story reflect casting and narrative choices. Writers might also have wanted to counter a viewer's confusion between $p(\text{black}|\text{criminal})$ and $p(\text{criminal}|\text{black})$ (see Bordalo et al. Forthcoming; Ahler and Sood 2016); political commitments could motivate such a choice. A commercial motive could also favor stories centered on white victims or criminals if producers expected those stories to attract viewers. We have no evidence about these production decisions or their effects on viewers, so these possibilities remain untested. The estimates here describe the coded characters in the sampled episodes.

References

Vinod Agarwal, Susan Hughes, Janet Molinaro, Ayush Toolsidass, Chris Colburn, Elizabeth Janik, Ken Plum, Shara Weber, Vicky Curtis, Feng Lian, Jim Sylvester, Gilbert Yochum, Steve Daniel, and Sharon Lomax. If it bleeds, does it still lead? local television evening news in hampton roads. In *The State of the Region*, pages 131–150. Old Dominion University, 2011.

Douglas J Ahler and Gaurav Sood. The parties in our heads: Misperceptions about party composition and their consequences. 2016.

G Blake Armstrong and Kimberly A Neuendorf. Tv entertainment, news, and racial perceptions of college students. *Journal of Communication*, 42(3):153–176, 1992.

Marianne Bertrand and Sendhil Mullainathan. Are emily and greg more employable than lakisha and jamal? a field experiment on labor market discrimination. *The American Economic Review*, 94(4):991–1013, 2004.

Eileen ES Bjornstrom, Robert L Kaufman, Ruth D Peterson, and Michael D Slater. Race and ethnic representations of lawbreakers and victims in crime news: A national study of television coverage. *Social problems*, 57(2):269–293, 2010.

Pedro Bordalo, Katherine Coffman, Nicola Gennaioli, and Andrei Shleifer. Stereotypes. *Quarterly Journal of Economics*, Forthcoming.

Rick Busselle and Heather Crandall. Television viewing and perceptions about race dif-

ferences in socioeconomic success. *Journal of Broadcasting & Electronic Media*, 46(2): 265–282, 2002.

Ted Chiricos and Sarah Eschholz. The racial and ethnic typification of crime and the criminal typification of race and ethnicity in local television news. *Journal of Research in Crime and Delinquency*, 39(4):400–420, 2002.

Jannette Lake Dates and William Barlow. *Split image: African Americans in the mass media*. Howard University Press, 1993.

Travis L Dixon. Psychological reactions to crime news portrayals of black criminals: Understanding the moderating roles of prior news viewing and stereotype endorsement. *Communication Monographs*, 73(2):162–187, 2006.

Travis L Dixon, Cristina L Azocar, and Michael Casas. The portrayal of race and crime on television network news. *Journal of Broadcasting & Electronic Media*, 47(4):498–523, 2003.

Travis Lemar Dixon and Daniel Linz. Overrepresentation and underrepresentation of african americans and latinos as lawbreakers on television news. *Journal of communication*, 50 (2):131–154, 2000.

Robert M Entman and Andrew Rojecki. *The black image in the white mind: Media and race in America*. Wiley Online Library, 2001.

Sarah Eschholz, Matthew Mallard, and Stacey Flynn. Images of prime time justice: a

content analysis of “nypd blue” and “law & order”. *Journal of Criminal Justice and Popular Culture*, 10(3):161–180, 2004.

George Gerbner, Larry Gross, Michael Morgan, and Nancy Signorielli. Living with television: The dynamics of the cultivation process. *Perspectives on media effects*, pages 17–40, 1986.

Franklin D Gilliam, Shanto Iyengar, Adam Simon, and Oliver Wright. Crime in black and white the violent, scary world of local news. *The Harvard International Journal of Press/Politics*, 1(3):6–23, 1996.

Kimberly Gross. Covering crime in washington, dc: Examining the nature of local television news coverage of crime and its effect on emotional response. 2006.

Jon Hurwitz and Mark Peffley. Public perceptions of race and crime: The role of racial stereotypes. *American journal of political science*, pages 375–401, 1997.

Shanto Iyengar. The accessibility bias in politics: Television news and public opinion. *International Journal of Public Opinion Research*, 2(1):1–15, 1990.

Shanto Iyengar and Donald R Kinder. *News that matters: Television and American opinion*. University of Chicago Press, 2010.

Maxwell E McCombs and Donald L Shaw. The agenda-setting function of mass media. *Public opinion quarterly*, 36(2):176–187, 1972.

Mark Peffley, Jon Hurwitz, and Paul M Sniderman. Racial stereotypes and whites' political

views of blacks in the context of welfare and crime. *American Journal of Political Science*, pages 30–60, 1997.

Ráchael A Powers. National crime victimization survey. *The Encyclopedia of Crime & Punishment*, 2016.

Narissra M Punyanunt-Carter. The perceived realism of african american portrayals on television. *The Howard Journal of Communications*, 19(3):241–257, 2008.

Karyn Riddle. Always on my mind: Exploring how frequent, recent, and vivid television portrayals are used in the formation of social reality judgments. *Media Psychology*, 13(2): 155–179, 2010.

James Shanahan and Michael Morgan. *Television and its viewers: Cultivation theory and research*. Cambridge University Press, 1999.

Paul M Sniderman and Thomas Leonard Piazza. *The scar of race*. Harvard University Press, 1995.

Darrell Steffensmeier, Ben Feldmeyer, Casey T Harris, and Jeffery T Ulmer. Reassessing trends in black violent crime, 1980–2008: Sorting out the "hispanic effect" in uniform crime reports arrests, national crime victimization survey offender estimates, and us prisoner counts. *Criminology*, 49(1):197–251, 2011.

Robert C Toll. *Blacking up: The minstrel show in nineteenth century America*. Oxford University Press, 1974.

Criminal Victimization. National crime victimization survey. *Washington, DC: US Dept of justice*, 1998.

Supporting Information

SI 1 Percentage of Black and Female Criminals and Victims in Law & Order By Year

Figure SI 1.1: Race of Criminals in Law & Order Original, SVU, and Criminal Intent by Year

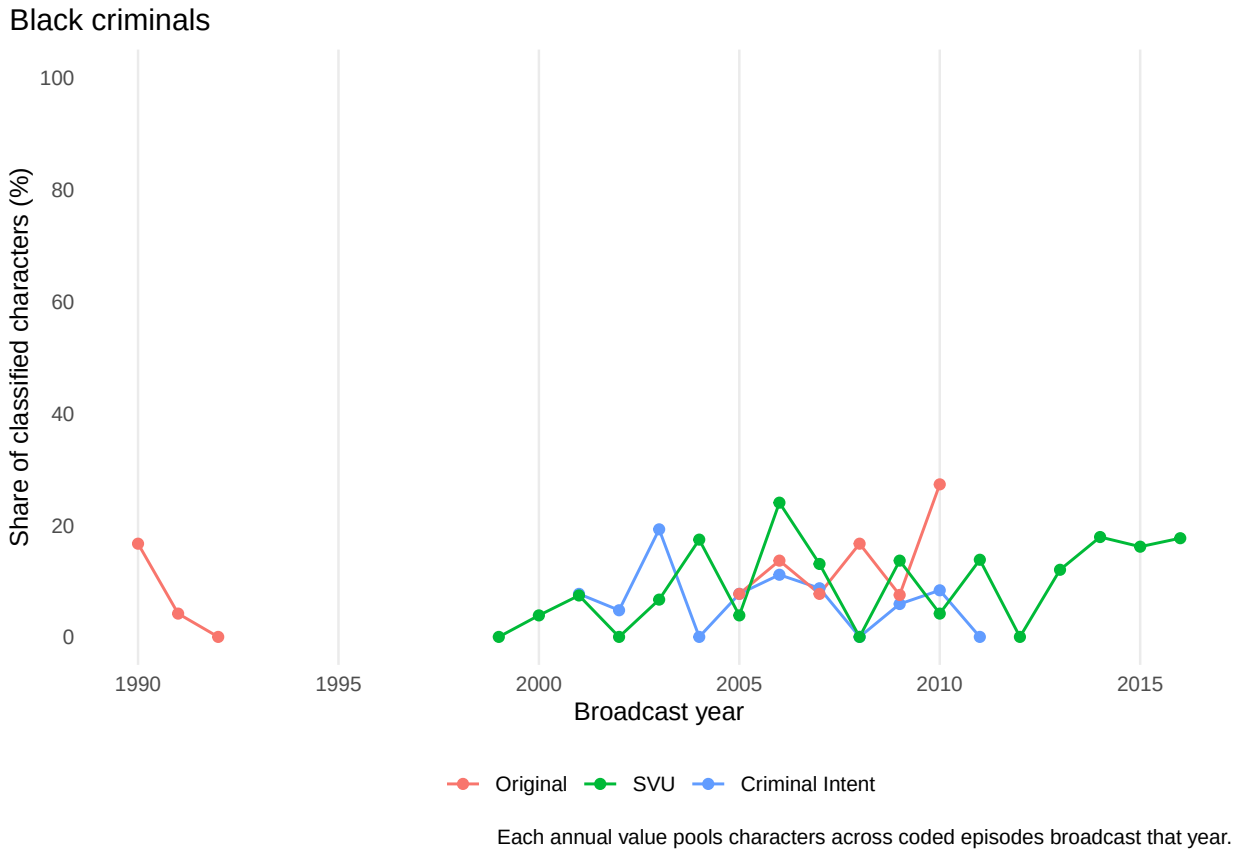


Figure SI 1.2: Race of Victims in Law & Order Original, SVU, and Criminal Intent by Year

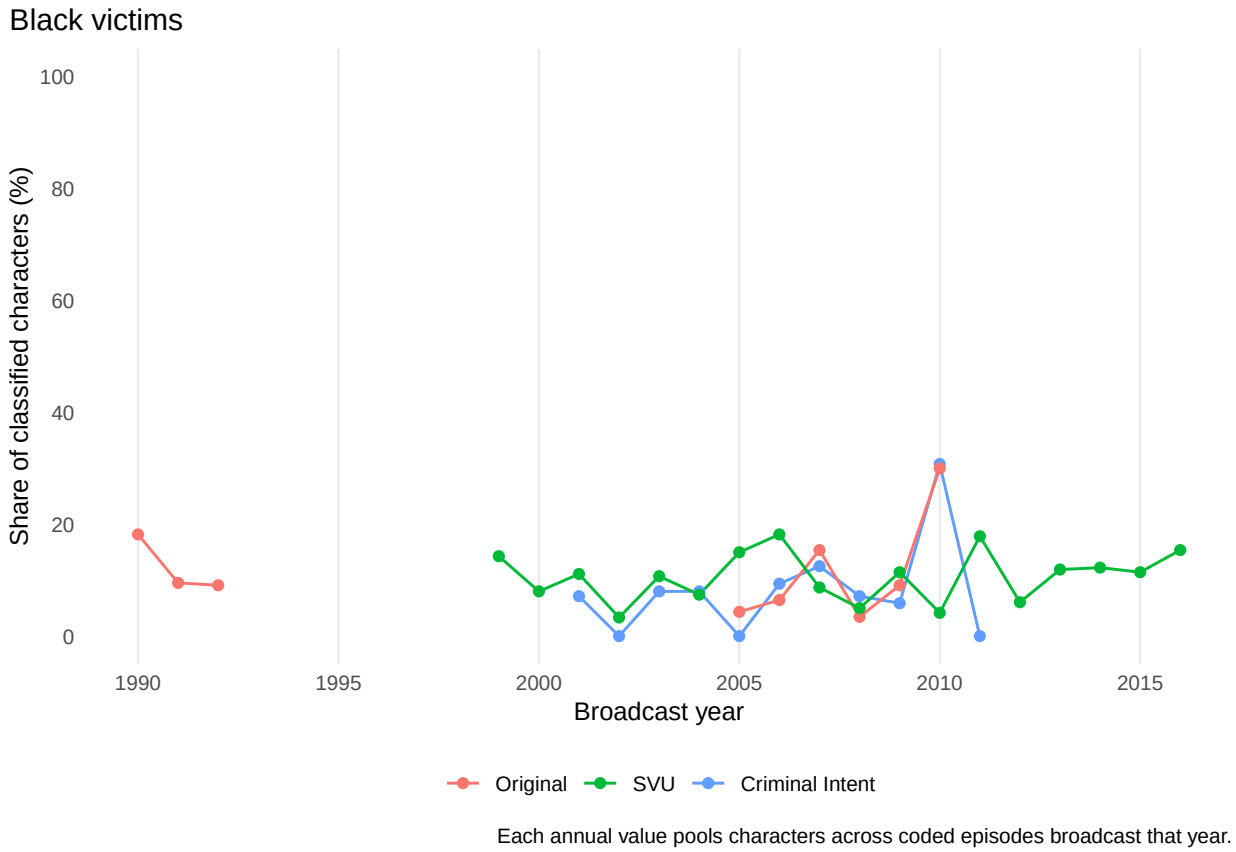


Figure SI 1.3: Gender of Criminals in Law & Order Original, SVU, and Criminal Intent by Year

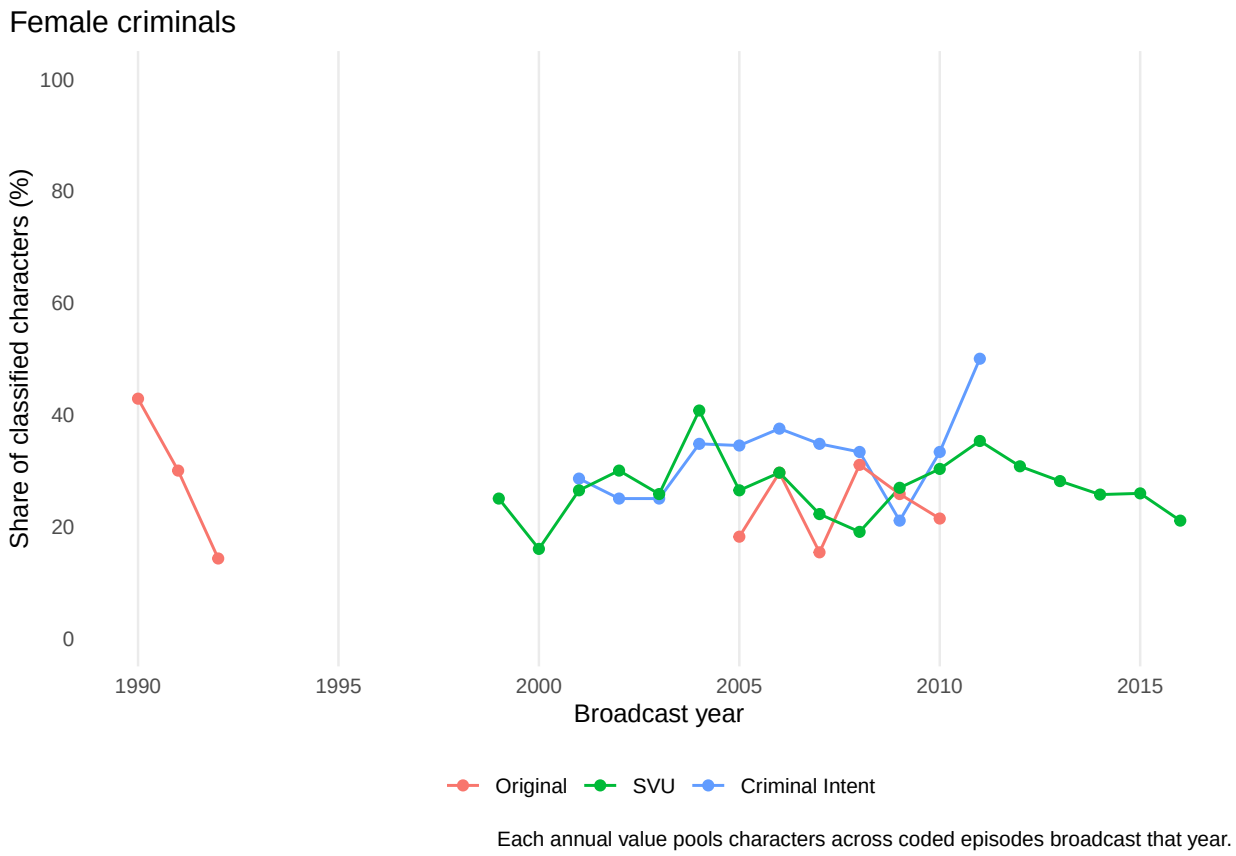
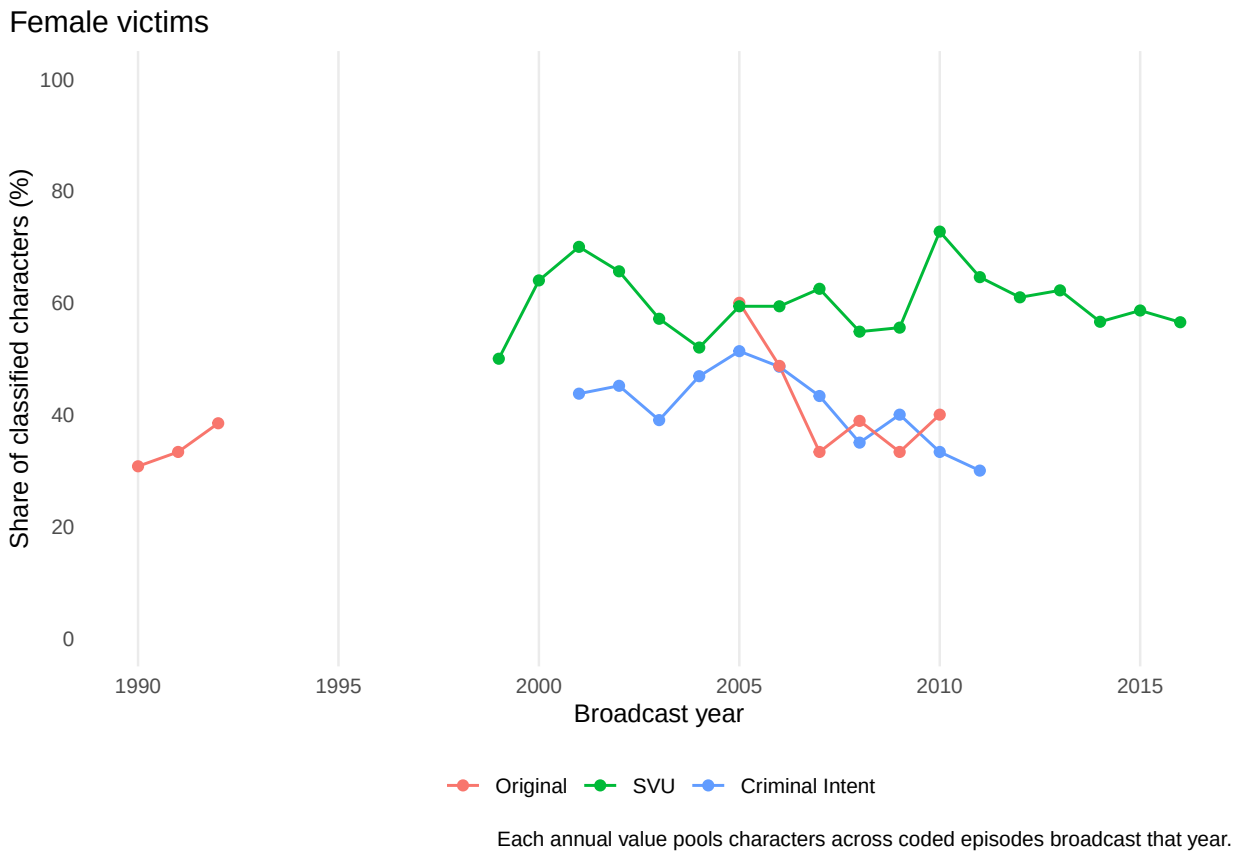


Figure SI 1.4: Gender of Victims in Law & Order Original, SVU, and Criminal Intent by Year



SI 2 Sex and Race of Criminals and Victims in Law & Order and Historical Reference Series

Table SI 2.1: Annual share of black victim characters and historical comparisons

Year	Criminal Intent	Original	SVU	NCVS serious violence	NCVS rape/sexual assault	NCVS aggravated assault	UCR murder victims	NYPD homicide victims	NYPD rape victims	US Census	NY Census
1990	–	18.2	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	12.0	28.8
1991	–	9.5	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–
1992	–	9.1	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–
1999	–	–	14.3	21.4	16.4	19.0	46.0	–	–	–	–
2000	–	–	8.0	16.0	9.2	13.8	48.0	–	–	12.3	26.6
2001	7.1	–	11.1	19.5	22.1	18.9	47.0	–	–	–	–
2002	0.0	–	3.3	22.1	27.3	22.2	48.0	–	–	–	–
2003	8.0	–	10.7	15.2	7.4	12.6	48.0	–	–	–	–
2004	8.0	–	7.4	20.0	19.1	16.7	47.0	–	–	–	–
2005	0.0	4.3	15.0	20.7	24.9	21.8	48.0	–	–	–	–
2006	9.4	6.5	18.2	21.8	18.9	27.8	50.0	–	–	–	–
2007	12.5	15.4	8.7	24.9	6.3	24.2	49.0	–	–	–	–
2008	7.1	3.4	5.0	19.2	16.3	16.4	48.0	62.1	40.6	–	–
2009	5.9	9.1	11.4	26.3	12.7	24.2	48.0	57.6	40.5	–	–
2010	30.8	30.0	4.2	19.1	12.2	21.1	50.0	67.0	40.9	12.6	25.5
2011	0.0	–	17.9	18.2	14.7	18.0	50.0	61.8	36.8	–	–
2012	–	–	6.1	17.9	5.6	18.6	51.0	60.1	37.9	–	–
2013	–	–	11.9	16.5	7.7	20.6	51.0	62.9	40.8	–	–
2014	–	–	12.2	17.3	22.6	15.1	51.0	62.4	39.7	–	–
2015	–	–	11.4	–	–	–	52.0	63.7	39.4	–	–
2016	–	–	15.4	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–

Values are percentages of classified characters in the shows or percentages reported by the historical comparison files. Missing years are shown as –.

Table SI 2.2: Annual share of black criminal characters and historical comparisons

Year	Criminal Intent	Original	SVU	UCR all arrests	UCR violent arrests	UCR homicide arrests	UCR rape arrests	UCR assault arrests	NYPD homicide suspects	NYPD rape suspects	US Census	NY Census
1990	–	16.7	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	12.0	28.8
1991	–	4.2	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–
1992	–	0.0	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–
1999	–	–	0.0	28.6	38.7	51.8	36.2	34.8	–	–	–	–
2000	–	–	3.8	27.9	37.8	48.8	34.1	34.0	–	–	12.3	26.6
2001	7.7	–	7.4	28.1	37.6	48.7	34.8	33.7	–	–	–	–
2002	4.8	–	0.0	26.9	38.0	50.0	34.0	34.2	–	–	–	–
2003	19.2	–	6.7	27.0	37.2	48.5	33.3	33.0	–	–	–	–
2004	0.0	–	17.4	26.8	36.9	47.2	31.9	32.7	–	–	–	–
2005	7.7	7.7	3.8	27.8	38.8	48.6	32.7	34.3	–	–	–	–
2006	11.1	13.6	24.0	28.0	39.3	50.9	32.5	34.5	–	–	–	–
2007	8.7	7.7	13.0	28.2	39.0	50.4	33.5	33.7	–	–	–	–
2008	0.0	16.7	0.0	28.3	39.4	50.1	32.2	34.2	60.8	52.8	–	–
2009	5.9	7.5	13.6	28.3	38.9	49.3	32.5	33.9	59.8	52.4	–	–
2010	8.3	27.3	4.2	28.0	38.1	48.7	31.8	33.5	60.9	52.6	12.6	25.5
2011	0.0	–	13.8	28.4	38.3	49.7	32.9	33.6	56.3	48.8	–	–
2012	–	–	0.0	28.1	38.5	49.4	32.5	34.1	53.7	50.5	–	–
2013	–	–	12.0	28.3	38.7	52.2	31.3	33.9	55.0	53.0	–	–
2014	–	–	17.9	27.8	37.7	51.3	29.9	33.1	59.8	49.3	–	–
2015	–	–	16.1	26.6	36.4	51.1	28.2	32.1	62.1	51.2	–	–
2016	–	–	17.6	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–

Values are percentages of classified characters in the shows or percentages reported by the historical comparison files. Missing years are shown as –.

Table SI 2.3: Annual share of female victim characters and historical comparisons

Year	Criminal Intent	Original	SVU	NCVS serious violence	NCVS rape/sexual assault	NCVS aggravated assault	UCR murder victims	US Census	NY Census
1990	–	30.8	–	–	–	–	–	51.3	53.2
1991	–	33.3	–	–	–	–	–	–	–
1992	–	38.5	–	–	–	–	–	–	–
1999	–	–	50.0	48.2	93.3	39.2	24.0	–	–
2000	–	–	64.0	38.1	96.0	27.1	24.0	50.9	52.6
2001	43.8	–	70.0	49.0	90.1	41.1	24.0	–	–
2002	45.2	–	65.6	49.3	86.6	44.0	23.0	–	–
2003	39.0	–	57.1	50.7	94.0	41.6	22.0	–	–
2004	46.9	–	52.0	45.4	97.6	37.1	22.0	–	–
2005	51.4	60.0	59.4	40.1	92.7	39.3	21.0	–	–
2006	48.6	48.7	59.4	47.4	77.6	42.5	21.0	–	–
2007	43.3	33.3	62.5	46.5	95.5	39.0	22.0	–	–
2008	35.0	38.9	54.8	54.9	88.7	47.2	22.0	–	–
2009	40.0	33.3	55.6	49.4	93.5	45.0	23.0	–	–
2010	33.3	40.0	72.7	52.5	94.4	43.2	23.0	50.8	52.5
2011	30.0	–	64.6	47.5	85.7	43.0	22.0	–	–
2012	–	–	61.0	42.3	62.2	42.5	22.0	–	–
2013	–	–	62.2	49.0	88.7	39.1	22.0	–	–
2014	–	–	56.6	46.9	90.1	39.6	23.0	–	–
2015	–	–	58.6	–	–	–	21.0	–	–
2016	–	–	56.5	–	–	–	–	–	–

Values are percentages of classified characters in the shows or percentages reported by the historical comparison files. Missing years are shown as –.

Table SI 2.4: Annual share of female criminal characters and historical comparisons

Year	Criminal Intent	Original	SVU	UCR all arrests	UCR violent arrests	UCR homicide arrests	UCR rape arrests	UCR assault arrests	US Census	NY Census
1990	–	42.9	–	–	–	–	–	–	51.3	53.2
1991	–	30.0	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–
1992	–	14.3	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–
1999	–	–	25.0	21.8	17.0	11.4	1.3	19.7	–	–
2000	–	–	16.0	22.2	17.4	10.6	1.1	20.1	50.9	52.6
2001	28.6	–	26.5	22.5	17.3	12.5	1.2	20.1	–	–
2002	25.0	–	30.0	23.0	17.4	10.8	1.4	20.2	–	–
2003	25.0	–	25.8	23.2	17.8	10.3	1.3	20.7	–	–
2004	34.8	–	40.7	23.8	17.9	11.5	1.5	20.8	–	–
2005	34.5	18.2	26.5	23.8	17.9	11.0	1.5	20.8	–	–
2006	37.5	29.6	29.6	23.7	17.8	10.9	1.3	20.7	–	–
2007	34.8	15.4	22.2	24.2	18.2	10.2	1.1	21.3	–	–
2008	33.3	31.0	19.0	24.5	18.3	10.8	1.2	21.5	–	–
2009	21.1	25.8	26.9	25.3	18.8	10.4	1.3	22.0	–	–
2010	33.3	21.4	30.3	25.5	19.5	10.9	1.1	22.6	50.8	52.5
2011	50.0	–	35.3	25.9	19.6	11.8	1.2	22.7	–	–
2012	–	–	30.8	26.2	19.9	11.3	0.9	22.9	–	–
2013	–	–	28.1	26.5	20.1	11.7	1.9	23.0	–	–
2014	–	–	25.7	26.7	20.2	11.5	2.8	23.0	–	–
2015	–	–	25.9	26.9	20.3	11.5	2.9	23.1	–	–
2016	–	–	21.1	–	–	–	–	–	–	–

Values are percentages of classified characters in the shows or percentages reported by the historical comparison files. Missing years are shown as –.